Saroja, the small-town girl who falls in love with a soda-pop vendor, is no Madame Bovary, the French provincial temptress who flaunts her sexuality with devastating effect in Gustave Flaubert's novel. Yet there are echoes of Perumal Murugan in Gustave Flaubert's confession: "Madame Bovary, *c'est moi* (Madame Bovary is me)!"

It's a similar tone that Murugan uses when asked how much of himself he has infused in his portrayal of Saroja's ordeals. "The writer doesn't merely write about his own experiences. A writer could absorb the experiences and feelings of others. If writing is shrunk into one's own experiences, it can't be universal. It's the ability to enter into others' experiences that drives writing into the realm of universality. In that sense, a writer can possess anyone's experience as his own. In that sense, this is my own experience," he says.

The steel bands of the caste system tighten around Saroja the moment she steps into the village, walking behind Kumaresan, her newly married husband. He cautions her to step with her right foot first when they alight from the bus. He is certain that his mother will welcome the bride he has chosen for himself. The mother lives in a mud-girt room, like a termite sheltered by a rock. He does not notice, as Saroja does, the thorny bushes that surround the village like barbed wire, the bleached landscape of deprivation. Or hear the diabolic cries of spite not unmixed with fear as members of the village arrive to view Saroja, not as the trophy that he had earned for himself, but as a harbinger of discord.

It's an epic opening. Yet, such is Murugan's lightness of touch that one is filled with a sense that despite the dismal auguries, there are erotic moments, like the casual flick of a cat's tail that awakens in Saroja the desire to accept her situation. While towards the end, as the encircling darkness envelopes Saroja, there comes the distant sound of a cycle bell winging its way home.

Murugan has every reason to rejoice at his latest book having been longlisted for this year's International Booker Prize. In 2015, he was like his heroine Saroja, the victim of irrational fears of those who, despite not having even read his book, wanted him silenced. He was reviled for what he wrote in *Maadhorubaagan* (One Part Woman), openly addressing feminine desire in ways that enraged the patriarchy. As right-wing vigilantes drove him out of his village, Murugan took the extreme step of announcing: "Perumal Murugan the writer is dead. Leave him alone."

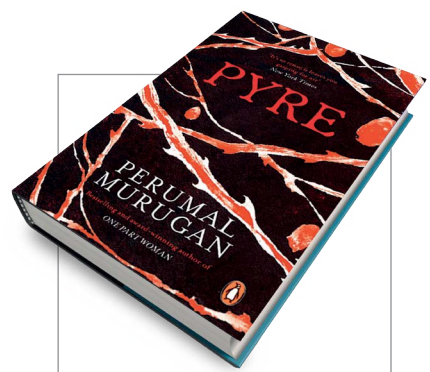
"What brought you back to life?" I ask him. His reply is terse and to the point. "The Tamil Nadu Progressive Writers and Artists Association had filed a case in the Madras High Court on the issue of 'Maadhorubaagan' #39. A bench comprising Chief Justice S.K. Kaul and Pushpa Sathyanarayana delivered the verdict in the case on July 5, 2016. It was a wonderful judgment on freedom of expression. It was this judgment that revived me and inspired me to write."

In 2016, Murugan introduced us to *Poonachi*, about a little black goat that is the seventh in the litter that struggles to survive. French writer Alphonse Daudet also wrote about the seventh goat in his short story, *The Goat of M. Seguin*. It was made into a children's story by Dr Zakir Husain, President of India, in the late 1960s, as *Abbu Khan's Goat*. Both stories highlight the struggle for freedom from bondage. "Do you think there is a universal reservoir of stories that writers sometimes discover to remind us of our common humanity?" I ask Murugan.

"I haven't read the story. I am keen to. It is also in the Tamil tradition to write imposing human nature on animals. *Poonachi* can also be read as the story of a goat, without reading it as imposing humanity on it. That makes *Poonachi* a unique work."

Pookuzhi, translated by Aniruddhan Vasudevan from Tamil into English as *Pyre*, comes alive through dialogues. Vasudevan in his foreword explains how Kumaresan's people and Saroja speak differently, the distance between the village and the outside: "It's been difficult to sustain that distance in translation. Perhaps, this is an instance where specificity of language use resists translatability."

It's in this context I find the single-word title 'Pyre' reductive. To the best of my understanding, the word 'Pookuzhi' also indicates the ordeal



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POOKUZHI, TRANSLATED INTO ENGLISH AS *PYRE* BY ANIRUDDHAN VASUDEVAN, COMES ALIVE THROUGH ITS DIALOGUES